



The 50-State Founding Facts Pack

One true, retellable founding fact for every state in the Union

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The 50 States — Founding Facts

In order of statehood. Each entry: order · statehood date · nickname · capital · a retell-it fact. All dates and facts verified — see .sources.md.

> For the first 13 states, "statehood date" is the date they **ratified the U.S. Constitution**. For > states 14-50, it is the date they were **admitted to the Union**.

1. Delaware — Dec 7, 1787 · "The First State" · Capital: Dover. Delaware was the first state to ratify the Constitution, and it did so unanimously — earning it the proud nickname "The First State."

2. Pennsylvania — Dec 12, 1787 · "The Keystone State" · Capital: Harrisburg. Founded by William Penn as a haven for Quakers, its name means "Penn's Woods." Philadelphia hosted the writing of both the Declaration and the Constitution.

3. New Jersey — Dec 18, 1787 · "The Garden State" · Capital: Trenton. Washington's Christmas-night crossing of the Delaware in 1776 led to his pivotal victory at Trenton, New Jersey.

4. Georgia — Jan 2, 1788 · "The Peach State" · Capital: Atlanta. Georgia was the last of the 13 original colonies to be founded (1733), named for King George II.

5. Connecticut — Jan 9, 1788 · "The Constitution State" · Capital: Hartford. Its 1639 Fundamental Orders are often called the first written constitution in the colonies.

6. Massachusetts — Feb 6, 1788 · "The Bay State" · Capital: Boston. The Revolution began here — the Boston Tea Party, Lexington, and Concord all took place in Massachusetts.

7. Maryland — Apr 28, 1788 · "The Old Line State" · Capital: Annapolis. Founded in 1634 as a refuge for Catholics; the bombardment of Fort McHenry in Baltimore inspired the national anthem.

8. South Carolina — May 23, 1788 · "The Palmetto State" · Capital: Columbia. Its palmetto-log fort repelled a British fleet in 1776, giving the state its palmetto emblem.

9. New Hampshire — Jun 21, 1788 · "The Granite State" · Capital: Concord. New Hampshire cast the decisive ninth vote that put the Constitution into effect. Its motto: "Live Free or Die."

10. Virginia — Jun 25, 1788 · "The Old Dominion" · Capital: Richmond. Home to more early presidents than any other state — Washington, Jefferson, Madison, and Monroe were all Virginians.

11. New York — Jul 26, 1788 · "The Empire State" · Capital: Albany. New York City was the nation's first capital; Washington was inaugurated there in 1789.

12. North Carolina — Nov 21, 1789 · "The Tar Heel State" · Capital: Raleigh. North Carolina held out and ratified only after the promise of a Bill of Rights.

13. Rhode Island — May 29, 1790 · "The Ocean State" · Capital: Providence. Founded by Roger Williams on religious freedom, it was the last of the 13 to ratify — and is the smallest state by area.

14. Vermont — Mar 4, 1791 · "The Green Mountain State" · Capital: Montpelier. Vermont was an independent republic for 14 years before joining the Union as the first new state.

15. Kentucky — Jun 1, 1792 · "The Bluegrass State" · Capital: Frankfort. Kentucky was carved out of Virginia's western frontier — the first state west of the Appalachians.

16. Tennessee — Jun 1, 1796 · "The Volunteer State" · Capital: Nashville. Its nickname honors the volunteers who answered the call to arms, especially in the War of 1812.

17. Ohio — Mar 1, 1803 · "The Buckeye State" · Capital: Columbus. The first state formed entirely from the Northwest Territory; birthplace of eight presidents.

18. Louisiana — Apr 30, 1812 · "The Pelican State" · Capital: Baton Rouge. Louisiana entered the Union nine years after the U.S. bought it from France in the Louisiana Purchase.

19. Indiana — Dec 11, 1816 · "The Hoosier State" · Capital: Indianapolis. Its name means "Land of the Indians," honoring the Native peoples of the region.

20. Mississippi — Dec 10, 1817 · "The Magnolia State" · Capital: Jackson. Named for the great river that forms its western border.

21. Illinois — Dec 3, 1818 · "The Prairie State" · Capital: Springfield. Springfield was Abraham Lincoln's hometown before he became president.

22. Alabama — Dec 14, 1819 · "The Yellowhammer State" · Capital: Montgomery. Its name comes from a Native American word thought to mean "tribal town" or "plant gatherers."

23. Maine — Mar 15, 1820 · "The Pine Tree State" · Capital: Augusta. Maine separated from Massachusetts and entered as a free state under the Missouri Compromise.

24. Missouri — Aug 10, 1821 · "The Show-Me State" · Capital: Jefferson City. Its capital is named for Thomas Jefferson; it was the gateway west for the Oregon and Santa Fe trails.

25. Arkansas — Jun 15, 1836 · "The Natural State" · Capital: Little Rock. Its name comes from a French rendering of a Native American word for the Quapaw people.

26. Michigan — Jan 26, 1837 · "The Great Lakes State" · Capital: Lansing. Michigan touches four of the five Great Lakes — more freshwater coastline than any other state.

27. Florida — Mar 3, 1845 · "The Sunshine State" · Capital: Tallahassee. St. Augustine, founded by the Spanish in 1565, is the oldest continuously occupied European-founded city in the U.S.

28. Texas — Dec 29, 1845 · "The Lone Star State" · Capital: Austin. Texas was an independent republic for nearly a decade before joining the Union — hence the lone star.

29. Iowa — Dec 28, 1846 · "The Hawkeye State" · Capital: Des Moines. Its nickname is said to honor the Native American leader Chief Black Hawk.

30. Wisconsin — May 29, 1848 · "The Badger State" · Capital: Madison. The "badger" nickname came from early lead miners who dug into hillsides like badgers.

31. California — Sep 9, 1850 · "The Golden State" · Capital: Sacramento. The 1849 Gold Rush swelled California's population so fast it skipped the territorial stage and entered directly as a state.

32. Minnesota — May 11, 1858 · "The North Star State" · Capital: Saint Paul. Its name comes from a Dakota word meaning "sky-tinted water," fitting a land of 10,000-plus lakes.

33. Oregon — Feb 14, 1859 · "The Beaver State" · Capital: Salem. The Oregon Trail brought tens of thousands of settlers west before statehood.

34. Kansas — Jan 29, 1861 · "The Sunflower State" · Capital: Topeka. Kansas entered the Union as a free state just before the Civil War began.

35. West Virginia — Jun 20, 1863 · "The Mountain State" · Capital: Charleston. West Virginia broke away from Virginia during the Civil War to remain in the Union — the only state formed by seceding from a Confederate state.

36. Nevada — Oct 31, 1864 · "The Silver State" · Capital: Carson City. Admitted during the Civil War partly for its silver wealth; its motto is "Battle Born."

37. Nebraska — Mar 1, 1867 · "The Cornhusker State" · Capital: Lincoln. Its capital was renamed for Abraham Lincoln; it has the nation's only single-house state legislature.

38. Colorado — Aug 1, 1876 · "The Centennial State" · Capital: Denver. Colorado joined exactly 100 years after independence — earning the nickname "The Centennial State."

39. North Dakota — Nov 2, 1889 · "The Peace Garden State" · Capital: Bismarck. Admitted the same day as South Dakota; the order was deliberately kept secret so neither could claim to be first.

40. South Dakota — Nov 2, 1889 · "The Mount Rushmore State" · Capital: Pierre. Home to Mount Rushmore, carved with the faces of Washington, Jefferson, Lincoln, and Theodore Roosevelt.

41. Montana — Nov 8, 1889 · "The Treasure State" · Capital: Helena. Named for its mountains (Spanish montaña), it was rich in gold, silver, and copper.

42. Washington — Nov 11, 1889 · "The Evergreen State" · Capital: Olympia. The only state named after a president — George Washington.

43. Idaho — Jul 3, 1890 · "The Gem State" · Capital: Boise. Idaho joined the Union one day before Independence Day in 1890.

44. Wyoming — Jul 10, 1890 · "The Equality State" · Capital: Cheyenne. Wyoming was the first place in the nation to grant women the right to vote, in 1869 — earning "The Equality State."

45. Utah — Jan 4, 1896 · "The Beehive State" · Capital: Salt Lake City. The beehive symbolizes industry and cooperation, values of the Mormon pioneers who settled it.

46. Oklahoma — Nov 16, 1907 · "The Sooner State" · Capital: Oklahoma City. "Sooners" were settlers who slipped in to claim land before the official land runs began.

47. New Mexico — Jan 6, 1912 · "The Land of Enchantment" · Capital: Santa Fe. Santa Fe, founded around 1610, is the oldest state capital in the United States.

48. Arizona — Feb 14, 1912 · "The Grand Canyon State" · Capital: Phoenix. Arizona was the last of the 48 contiguous states admitted to the Union.

49. Alaska — Jan 3, 1959 · "The Last Frontier" · Capital: Juneau. Purchased from Russia in 1867, Alaska is by far the largest state — bigger than Texas, California, and Montana combined.

50. Hawaii — Aug 21, 1959 · "The Aloha State" · Capital: Honolulu. The 50th and newest state, and the only one made up entirely of islands. Its admission gave the flag its 50th star.

The 13 Original Colonies

The states of the founding generation — the ones that declared independence in 1776. These are the emotional heart of the America-250 story. Verified — see .sources.md.

The 13 colonies are usually grouped into three regions: **New England**, the **Middle Colonies**, and the **Southern Colonies**. Below, each colony's founding and the one fact that made it distinct.

New England Colonies

Massachusetts Bay — settled 1620 (Plymouth) and 1630 (Boston). The Pilgrims landed at Plymouth in 1620 and signed the Mayflower Compact, an early agreement to self-government. A decade later the Puritans founded Boston. Massachusetts became the cradle of the Revolution.

New Hampshire — settled 1623. One of the earliest New England settlements, it was long tied to Massachusetts before becoming its own colony. Its "Live Free or Die" spirit runs deep.

Rhode Island — founded 1636 by Roger Williams. Banished from Massachusetts for his beliefs, Roger Williams founded Providence as a refuge for religious freedom — a founding principle of the whole nation.

Connecticut — founded 1636. Its 1639 Fundamental Orders are often called the first written framework of government in the colonies, earning it "The Constitution State."

Middle Colonies

New York — founded 1624 as New Netherland (Dutch), became English in 1664. Originally the Dutch colony of New Amsterdam, it was renamed New York after the English took control. New York City later became the nation's first capital.

New Jersey — established as an English colony in 1664. Split from New York, it sat between two great port cities and saw more Revolutionary War battles than almost any

other colony.

Pennsylvania — founded 1681 by William Penn. Granted to Quaker William Penn, "Penn's Woods" was founded on religious tolerance. Philadelphia became the birthplace of the Declaration and the Constitution.

Delaware — settled 1638, long tied to Pennsylvania. Once "the Lower Counties" of Pennsylvania, Delaware became its own state and then the very first to ratify the Constitution in 1787.

Southern Colonies

Maryland — founded 1634 by Lord Baltimore. Established as a haven for English Catholics, it passed an early act of religious toleration in 1649.

Virginia — founded 1607 at Jamestown. Jamestown was the first permanent English settlement in America. Virginia produced four of the first five presidents.

North Carolina — the Carolina colony was chartered 1663; split into North and South in 1712. Frontier and independent-minded, North Carolina held out for a Bill of Rights before ratifying the Constitution.

South Carolina — the Carolina colony was chartered 1663; split into North and South in 1712. Charleston grew into a major colonial port; its palmetto-log fort repelled a British fleet in 1776.

Georgia — founded 1733 by James Oglethorpe. The last of the 13 colonies, Georgia was founded as a fresh-start colony and named for King George II.

Together, these 13 became the first stars on the flag — and the first 13 stripes still honor them today.

Quick-Reference Tables

Printable one-page charts. Verified — see [.sources.md](#).

Table A — All 50 States by Statehood Order

#	State	Date	#	State	Date
1	Delaware	Dec 7, 1787	26	Michigan	Jan 26, 1837
2	Pennsylvania	Dec 12, 1787	27	Florida	Mar 3, 1845
3	New Jersey	Dec 18, 1787	28	Texas	Dec 29, 1845
4	Georgia	Jan 2, 1788	29	Iowa	Dec 28, 1846
5	Connecticut	Jan 9, 1788	30	Wisconsin	May 29, 1848
6	Massachusetts	Feb 6, 1788	31	California	Sep 9, 1850
7	Maryland	Apr 28, 1788	32	Minnesota	May 11, 1858
8	South Carolina	May 23, 1788	33	Oregon	Feb 14, 1859
9	New Hampshire	Jun 21, 1788	34	Kansas	Jan 29, 1861
10	Virginia	Jun 25, 1788	35	West Virginia	Jun 20, 1863
11	New York	Jul 26, 1788	36	Nevada	Oct 31, 1864
12	North Carolina	Nov 21, 1789	37	Nebraska	Mar 1, 1867
13	Rhode Island	May 29, 1790	38	Colorado	Aug 1, 1876
14	Vermont	Mar 4, 1791	39	North Dakota	Nov 2, 1889
15	Kentucky	Jun 1, 1792	40	South Dakota	Nov 2, 1889
16	Tennessee	Jun 1, 1796	41	Montana	Nov 8, 1889
17	Ohio	Mar 1, 1803	42	Washington	Nov 11, 1889

#	State	Date	#	State	Date
18	Louisiana	Apr 30, 1812	43	Idaho	Jul 3, 1890
19	Indiana	Dec 11, 1816	44	Wyoming	Jul 10, 1890
20	Mississippi	Dec 10, 1817	45	Utah	Jan 4, 1896
21	Illinois	Dec 3, 1818	46	Oklahoma	Nov 16, 1907
22	Alabama	Dec 14, 1819	47	New Mexico	Jan 6, 1912
23	Maine	Mar 15, 1820	48	Arizona	Feb 14, 1912
24	Missouri	Aug 10, 1821	49	Alaska	Jan 3, 1959
25	Arkansas	Jun 15, 1836	50	Hawaii	Aug 21, 1959

Table B — All 50 Capitals at a Glance

Alabama: Montgomery · Alaska: Juneau · Arizona: Phoenix · Arkansas: Little Rock · California: Sacramento · Colorado: Denver · Connecticut: Hartford · Delaware: Dover · Florida: Tallahassee · Georgia: Atlanta · Hawaii: Honolulu · Idaho: Boise · Illinois: Springfield · Indiana: Indianapolis · Iowa: Des Moines · Kansas: Topeka · Kentucky: Frankfort · Louisiana: Baton Rouge · Maine: Augusta · Maryland: Annapolis · Massachusetts: Boston · Michigan: Lansing · Minnesota: Saint Paul · Mississippi: Jackson · Missouri: Jefferson City · Montana: Helena · Nebraska: Lincoln · Nevada: Carson City · New Hampshire: Concord · New Jersey: Trenton · New Mexico: Santa Fe · New York: Albany · North Carolina: Raleigh · North Dakota: Bismarck · Ohio: Columbus · Oklahoma: Oklahoma City · Oregon: Salem · Pennsylvania: Harrisburg · Rhode Island: Providence · South Carolina: Columbia · South Dakota: Pierre · Tennessee: Nashville · Texas: Austin · Utah: Salt Lake City · Vermont: Montpelier · Virginia: Richmond · Washington: Olympia · West Virginia: Charleston · Wisconsin: Madison · Wyoming: Cheyenne.

Table C — Superlatives

- **First state to ratify the Constitution:** Delaware (Dec 7, 1787).
 - **Last of the original 13 to ratify:** Rhode Island (May 29, 1790).
 - **Last of the 48 contiguous states admitted:** Arizona (Feb 14, 1912).
 - **Newest state:** Hawaii (Aug 21, 1959), the 50th.
 - **Largest states by area:** Alaska, Texas, California, Montana, New Mexico.
 - **Smallest states by area:** Rhode Island, Delaware, Connecticut, New Jersey, New Hampshire.
 - **Only state named after a U.S. president:** Washington.
 - **Oldest state capital:** Santa Fe, New Mexico (founded around 1610).
 - **Joined exactly 100 years after independence:** Colorado, 1876 ("The Centennial State").
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Table D — "How Many Can You Name?" Challenge Sheet

Fold this over and test yourself on the table. Answers are in Table A / Table B above.

1. Name all 13 original states (the first to ratify).

2. Name the 5 largest states by area.

3. Name the 5 smallest states by area.

4. Which state was the 50th? _____

5. Which state is named after a president?

6. Which state joined exactly 100 years after 1776?

7. Name your own state's: statehood year _____ · nickname _____ ·
capital _____

8. How many of all 50 capitals can you name from memory? Score: _____ / 50